The Little Lantern

A short story about courage, kindness, and finding your own light

Chapter One — The Storm

The rain began just before sunset. At first, it was soft enough to sound like fingers tapping against the windows of the little houses in Willow Lane. But within an hour, the wind had grown strong, the clouds had turned almost black, and the narrow streets were shining beneath the rain.

Mira stood beside the window of her grandmother's old house and watched the storm. She was sixteen and had always been fascinated by the small lighthouse on the hill outside the village. It had not been used for many years, but every evening an old lantern still hung in its window. People said that the lantern had once helped travelers find their way home.

That evening, however, the lantern was dark.

“Grandmother,” Mira asked, “why doesn't anyone light the lantern anymore?”

Her grandmother looked up from her knitting. “Because everyone believes the lighthouse has nothing left to give,” she said. “The lamp is old, the road is difficult, and people stopped believing that one small light could make a difference.”

Mira looked back at the hill. Through the rain, she could barely see its outline.

Then she noticed something unusual. Far beyond the village, a tiny light appeared and disappeared between the waves. A fishing boat was still out on the water.

“Someone is coming home,” Mira whispered.

Her grandmother followed her gaze. “Then perhaps they need a light.”

Mira immediately ran to the small storage room beneath the stairs. She found an old oil lamp, a box of matches, and a thick woolen coat. The lighthouse was at the top of the hill, and the storm was getting worse, but she knew what she had to do.

Chapter Two — A Light in the Dark

The path to the lighthouse was slippery. Rain soaked Mira's coat, and the wind pushed against her so hard that several times she had to stop and hold onto the stone wall. Still, she continued climbing.

When she finally reached the lighthouse, she was exhausted. The wooden door creaked open, revealing a dusty room filled with broken equipment. At the top of the tower stood the old lantern.

Mira cleaned the glass with her sleeve and carefully filled the lamp with oil. Her hands trembled as she struck a match.

The first match went out.

The second match went out too.

“Please,” Mira whispered. “Just one more.”

The third match caught the wick. A small golden flame appeared.

For a moment, Mira thought the light looked almost too small to matter. Then she remembered what her grandmother had said: people had stopped believing that one small light could make a difference.

She opened the lantern's shutters.

The golden light spread across the dark water.

Far away, the fishing boat turned.

Mira watched as it slowly moved toward the village. She stayed beside the lantern until the storm began to weaken. At last, she saw the boat enter the harbor safely.

By morning, the entire village knew what had happened. The fishermen had seen the lighthouse through the storm and used its light to find the harbor.

The villagers climbed the hill that afternoon. They repaired the lighthouse, replaced the broken windows, and cleaned the old lantern. From that day forward, someone always made sure its flame was burning at sunset.

Years later, Mira became the lighthouse keeper. Whenever a child asked her why she kept the old lantern burning, she smiled and gave the same answer:

“Because you never know how far a little light can travel.”

And whenever the night was darkest, the little lantern continued to shine over Willow Lane—a quiet reminder that courage does not always look like something enormous. Sometimes, courage is simply taking one small step when you are afraid, and believing that your small light might help someone else find their way home.